

WHAT'S THE METAVERSE?

NO, IT'S NOT JUST A LONGER FORM OF FACEBOOK INC'S NEW NAME...

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In mid-October 2021 we heard rumours of Facebook Inc. changing its name to something new, most bets were on the new name being something to do with the metaverse. Many people, including those of us in Team Digit were convinced it would be Meta or Metaverse, because it was not a secret that this was the direction Facebook was heading in. It wasn't just Facebook's announcement that suddenly formed the metaverse out of thin air, even though it feels like it because that's the power of Facebook. If anything the metaverse is much older than it seems.

Tech pundits have seen this coming ever since Facebook bought Oculus in March 2014. VR has promised to be the next big thing for a decade now, and here at Digit we've been waiting with bated breath for the first successful brain computer interface (BCI) for at least 15 years. I've written about BCIs myself several times over the past decade and a half! In short, the direction we're headed in has not been a secret to anyone who follows the tech industry, and certainly not surprising to those of you who have been reading Digit for more than a decade.

Science fiction writers have been writing about this for even longer, and though they were not prescient enough to imagine the leaps in terms of computing and the miniaturisation of everything, the general trend was towards

computers/machines/robots that were smart, and us interfacing with them as one would the real world.

The term "metaverse" itself is a portmanteau (blending of words) of the prefix "meta" with the word "universe". It was first used in Neal Stephenson's book, *Snow Crash*, in 1992, and it's a use that all of us would identify with immediately. In the book, Stephenson's description of the Metaverse conjures up images of a virtual reality world, or universe, where nothing is real, and people can live in a fantasy, or if they choose to, live very average lives.

Those familiar with my writing style know how I like to veer off course for a bit, so brace yourselves.

To understand what meta is you have to first have watched the movie *Inception*. If you haven't, go watch it now, then come back, because the great thing about magazines is that waiting for 148 minutes before continuing is easy. Well, maybe longer than 148 minutes, because like most of us who have watched it, you probably had to do some internet searches to try and understand what the heck it was you just watched.

Back? Now that you have been subjected to mind-bending explanations of dreams within dreams, or dreams about dreams, you're ready to understand what on earth the term "meta" actually means.

Just as dreams about dreams could be considered to be meta-

dreams, data about data is considered 'metadata'. A joke about a joke is a metajoke, metamathematics is the mathematical study of mathematical principles, metafiction is a fictional work about a fictional work, metaprogramming is programming of programs that program another program... and now you understand why I wanted you to watch *Inception* first... don't be fooled into thinking all words that start with meta mean <something> of <the same something>, because that's not actually the case, but many words where it is an obvious prefix do tend to mean that. Cognition of cognition = metacognition, the study of languages is linguistics, the study of relation between different languages is metalinguistics, etc.

THE METAVERSE

So what's the meta-universe? What's "meta" about Facebook anyway? For some people, nothing at all, for others, it's exactly what the name suggests... a universe within a universe.

Most people will point to the game *Second Life* as perhaps the first stab taken at creating a 'cyberverse' (cyber-universe), and for most people, there really is no difference between the cyberverse and the metaverse. Come to think of it, for most people, cyberspace, cyberverse and metaverse all can be used pretty interchangeably for one another. However, are those people correct?